



American Speech-Language-Hearing Association

Making effective communication, a human right, accessible and achievable for all.



Common Medical Abbreviations

A

A.A.R.O.M.	active assistive range of motion
AAC	augmentative and alternative communication
A.B.G	arterial blood gas
a.c.	before meals
A/C	assist control
ADA Diet	American Diabetes Association Diet
A.D.L.	activities of daily living
A.Fib.	atrial fibrillation
AKA	above-knee amputation or above-the-knee amputation
ALS	amyotrophic lateral sclerosis
AMA	against medical advice
A&O	alert and oriented
A/P	anterior–posterior
A.R.O.M.	active range of motion
ASAP	as soon as possible
ASD	autism spectrum disorder

ASL	American Sign Language
B	
b.i.d.	twice a day
BJA	below-knee amputation
B/L	bilateral
B.L.BS	bilateral breath sounds
BMR	basal metabolism rate
BP	blood pressure
BR	bed rest
bs	bowel sounds
BS	breath sounds
B/S	bedside
bx	biopsy
C	
ċ	with
C	Celsius, centigrade
C1, C2, etc.	first cervical vertebrae, second cervical vertebrae, etc.
CA	cardiac arrest
CA, ca	cancer, carcinoma
CABG	coronary artery bypass graft
CAD	coronary artery disease
cal	calorie
cath	catheter
CBC	complete blood count

cc	cubic centimeter
CC	chief complaint
CHF	congestive heart failure, chronic heart failure
CCU	coronary care unit
CHI	closed head injury
cm	centimeter
CMT	continuing medication and treatment
CN	cranial nerve
CNA	certified nursing assistant
CNS	central nervous system
c/o	complains of
COTA	certified occupational therapy assistant
cont	continue(d)
COPD	chronic obstructive pulmonary disease
CP	cerebral palsy
CPAP	continuous positive airway pressure
CPR	cardiopulmonary resuscitation
CRF	chronic renal failure
CRNP	certified registered nurse practitioner
CSF	cerebrospinal fluid
CT	computerized tomography
CV	cardiovascular
CVA	cerebral vascular accident
CXR	chest X-ray

D	
d	day
d/c	discontinue
DC	discharge
DM	diabetes mellitus
DNK	do not know
DNKA	did not keep appointment
DNR	do not resuscitate
DNT	did not test
DOA	dead on arrival
DOB	date of birth
DOE	dyspnea on exertion
d/t	due to
Dx	diagnosis
E	
ECC, EKG	electrocardiogram
ED	emergency department
EEG	electroencephalogram
EENT	eyes, ears, nose, throat
EMG	electromyogram
ENT	ears, nose, throat
ER	emergency room
ETOH	ethanol (alcohol)
exam	examination

ext	external, exterior
F	
F	Fahrenheit
FH	family history
fib	fibrillation
fl, fld	fluid
FOB	foot of bed
f/u	follow-up
FWB	full weight bearing
Fx	fracture
G	
GB	gall bladder
GCS	Glasgow Coma Scale
GE	gastroenterology
GERD	gastroesophageal reflux disease
G/E	gastroenteritis
gen	general
gest.	gestation
G.I.	gastrointestinal
GNA	geriatric nursing assistant
gluc	glucose
GP	general practitioner, general paralysis
GSW	gunshot wound
GTT	glucose tolerance test

Gt. tr.	gait training
GYN	gynecology
H	
h	hour
H/A	headache
HAV	hepatitis A virus
Hb.	hemoglobin
HB	heart block
HBP	high blood pressure
h.d.	at bedtime
HEENT	head, eyes, ears, nose, throat
HEP	home exercise program
H ₂ O	water
h/o	history of
HOB	head of bed
H&P	history and physical
HR	heart rate
HTN	hypertension
HVD	hypertensive vascular disease
Hx	history
Hz	hertz (cycles/second)
I	
ICCU	intensive coronary care unit
ICP	intracranial pressure

ICU	intensive care unit
imp.	impression
incr.	increased(ing)
inf	infusion, inferior
inspire	inspiration, inspiratory
int.	internal
I&O	intake and output
IPPB	intermittent positive pressure breathing
irreg.	irregular
IV	intravenous(ly)
J	
J, jt.	joint
K	
K	potassium, kidney
L	
L	left, liver, liter, lower, light, lumbar
L2, L3	second lumbar vertebrae, third lumbar vertebrae
lab	laboratory
lac.	laceration
lat.	lateral
LBW	low birth rate
L.E.	lower extremities
liq.	liquid
L.O.C.	loss of consciousness, level of consciousness, laxative of choice

LOS	length of stay
LP	lumbar puncture
LPN	licensed practical nurse
LUE	left upper extremity
Lx	larynx
L&W	living and well
M	
m, M	married, male, mother, murmur, meter, mass, molar
max.	maximum, maxillary
MBC	maximum breathing capacity
MBSS	modified barium swallow study
MCA	middle cerebral artery
MD	muscular dystrophy
mdnt.	midnight
med.	medicine
mets.	metastasis
MG	myasthenia gravis
MI	myocardial infarction
min	minute
MICU	medical intensive care unit
mod	moderate
MRI	magnetic resonance imaging
MRSA	methicillin-resistant <i>Staphylococcus aureus</i>
mss	massage

MVA	motor vehicle accident
N	
n.	nerve
Na	sodium
NaCl	sodium chloride
NAD	no abnormality detected
NAD	no apparent distress
neg.	negative
neur.	neurology
NG	nasogastric
NIC	neonatal intensive care
NICU	neonatal intensive care unit
NKA	no known allergies
no.	number
NOS	not otherwise specified
NPO	nothing by mouth
NSA	no specific abnormality
NST	nonstress test
N&V	nausea and vomiting
NVD	nausea, vomiting, diarrhea
N&W	normal and well
NWB	non–weight bearing
NYD	not yet diagnosed
O	

o	none, without
O	oral
O ₂	oxygen
O ₂ cap.	oxygen capacity
O ₂ sat.	oxygen saturation
OA	osteoarthritis
OB, OBG	obstetrics
OB/GYN	obstetrics and gynecology
Obs	observation
OBS	organic brain syndrome
ODD	oppositional defiant disorder
O/E	on examination
OH	occupational history
OHD	organic heart disease
oint.	ointment
O.M.	otitis media
O.M.E.	otitis media with effusion
OOB, oob	out of bed
Op.	operation
ot.	ear
Oto	otolaryngology
OTC	over-the-counter (pharmaceuticals)
O.T.	occupational therapy, old tuberculin
OR	operating room

P	
PA	physician's assistant
p&a	percussion and auscultation
PACU	post anesthesia care unit
PAF	paroxysmal atrial fibrillation
palp.	palpate, palpated, palpable
Path	pathology
PA view	posterior–anterior view on X-ray
p/c, p.c.	after meals
PD	Parkinson's disease
pdr.	powder
PDN	private duty nurse
PE	physical exam, pulmonary embolism, pressure equalizer (tubes)
Ped.	pediatrics
PEEP	positive end-expiratory pressure
PEG	percutaneous endoscopic gastrostomy
PET	positron emission tomography
PH	past history
pharm	pharmacy
PHYS.	physical, physiology
PI	present illness, pulmonary insufficiency
PICU	pulmonary intensive care unit
PID	pelvic inflammatory disease
plts.	platelets

P.M.	afternoon, postmortem
PMH	past medical history
PMR	physical medicine and rehabilitation
PN	poorly nourished, practical nurse
P&N	psychiatry and neurology
PNA	pneumo, pneumonia
PNI	peripheral nerve injury
PNX	pneumothorax
p.o.	by mouth
p.o.d.	postoperative day
pos.	positive
post.	posterior
POSTOP.	postoperative
pot. or potass.	potassium
PR	proctology
pre-op	preoperative
prep.	prepare for
p.r.m.	according to circumstances
p.r.n., PRN	as often as necessary, as needed
prod.	productive
Prog.	prognosis
PROM	passive range of motion
pron.	pronator, pronation
prosth.	prosthesis

PSH	past surgical history
Psych.	psychiatry
pt., Pt.	patient
PT, P.T.	physical therapy
PTA	prior to admission
PTA pulse	posterior tibial artery pulse
PUD	peptic ulcer disease
PVD	peripheral vascular disease
PVT	previous trouble
PWB%	partial weight bearing with percent
Px, PX	physical examination
Q	
q	every
q.h.	every hour
q.i.d.	four times a day
qt.	quart
quad.	quadriplegic
R	
R, r	right
R.	rub, rectal temperature
RA	rheumatoid arthritis, right atrium
rad.	radial
r.a.m.	rapid alternating movements
R.A.S.	right arm sitting

RAtx	radiation therapy
rbc/RBC	red blood cell, red blood count
RCA	right coronary artery
RCU	respiratory care unit
RD	respiratory distress
RDS	respiratory distress syndrome
RE	reconditioning exercise
reg.	regular
rehab.	rehabilitation
resp.	respiratory, respirations
RF	rheumatic fever
RLAS	Rancho Los Amigos Scale
R to L&A	react to light and accommodation
RLE	right lower extremity
RN	registered nurse
RND	radical neck dissection
RO, R/O	rule out
ROM	range of motion, rupture of membranes, right otitis media
ROS	review of symptoms
Rt.	right
RT	radiation therapy, respiratory therapy
RUE	right upper extremity
RV	residual volume
RW	rolling walker

Rx	therapy, prescription
S	
s	without
S	sensation, sensitive, serum
Sa.	saline
s.c.	subcutaneous(ly)
ScC	squamous cell carcinoma
SCCA	squamous cell carcinoma, squamous cell carcinoma antigen
SCD	sudden cardiac death
SCI	spinal cord injury
schiz	schizophrenia
SCU	special care unit
sec	second
Sens.	sensory, sensation
sep.	separated
SGA	small for gestational age
s.gl.	without correction (without glasses)
SH	social history
SI	stroke index
sib.	sibling
SICU	surgical intensive care unit
SIDS	sudden infant death syndrome
skel.	skeletal
Sl.	slightly

SL	under the tongue
SLP	speech-language pathologist
sm	small
SNF	skilled nursing facility
SOAP	subjective, objective, assessment, plan
SOB	shortness of breath
S/P, s/p	status post (previous condition)
sp. cd.	spinal cord
spec.	specimen
sp. fl.	spinal fluid
sp&H	speech and hearing
spin.	spine, spinal
spont.	spontaneous
s/s	signs and symptoms
SS	social service
ST	speech therapy
stat., STAT	immediately
STD	sexually transmitted disease
subcut.	subcutaneous
subling.	sublingual
sup.	superior
supin.	supination
surg.	surgery, surgical
Sx	symptoms

sys.	system
Syst.	systolic
Sz	seizure
T	
T	temperature
T&A	tonsils and adenoids, tonsillectomy and adenoidectomy
tab.	tablet
TAH	total abdominal hysterectomy
TB	tuberculosis
TBI	traumatic brain injury
temp	temperature
THERAP.	therapy, therapeutic
THR	total hip replacement
TIA	transient ischemic attack
TKR	total knee replacement
TNM	tumor, nodes, and metastases
TO	telephone order
TPN	total parenteral nutrition
TPR	temperature, pulse, respiration
tr	trace
trach	tracheostomy
tsp.	teaspoon
Tx	treatment, traction
U	

U/A	urinalysis
UCD, UCHD	usual childhood diseases
UG	upward gaze
Unilat.	unilateral
u/o	under observation
Ur.	urine
URD	upper respiratory disease
URI	upper respiratory infection
Urol.	urology
u/s, US	ultrasound
UTI	urinary tract infection
V	
V	vein
VA	visual acuity
vag	vagina, vaginal
VC, vit.cap.	vital capacity
VD	venereal disease
vent.	ventilator
vert.	vertical
VF	visual fields, ventricular fibrillation
VFSS	videofluoroscopic swallowing study
Via	by way of
vit.	vitamin
VN	visiting nurse

VO	verbal order
VS, V.S.	vital signs
W	
w, wk	week
W/C, wh.ch.	wheelchair
WBT	weight bearing tolerance
WFL	within functional limits
w/n	within
WNL	within normal limits
WP	whirlpool
wt.	weight
w/u	workup
X	
x	times
Y	
y.o.	years old
yrs.	years

This list is not exhaustive. Note that some abbreviations overlap (e.g., CA could mean "cardiac arrest" or "carcinoma"). Please avoid using abbreviations if their meaning is unclear.